On the Ethics of Belief

Second Author

1. The Question

When we accept what another person tells us, we seem to acquire knowledge without ever inspecting the evidence ourselves.[1] This familiar fact has struck many philosophers as puzzling, since it appears to make the epistemic standing of a belief depend on features of a speaker that the hearer cannot directly observe.

One natural response holds that testimony is merely a species of inductive inference. On this view, the hearer reasons from the past reliability of speakers to the probable truth of the present report, and the justification transmitted is never more than the justification supplied by that background generalisation.

The reductionist picture faces a well-known difficulty.[2] Very few of us have checked enough reports to ground the sweeping generalisations the view requires, and children certainly have not, yet we do not ordinarily think that a child who learns the names of the planets from a teacher thereby fails to know them.

Anti-reductionists respond by positing a default entitlement to accept what we are told in the absence of defeaters. The entitlement is not earned by the hearer's own inquiry; it is a standing feature of our cognitive situation as members of a linguistic community whose practices of assertion are governed by norms of sincerity and competence.

It would be a mistake, however, to treat the dispute as a simple choice between two rival theses.[3] Both parties agree that a hearer who ignores obvious signs of deception is epistemically criticisable, and both agree that the reliability of the speaker matters to whether knowledge is transmitted at all.

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[1] The locus classicus is usually taken to be the eighteenth-century debate, though the terms of that debate differ in important respects from the contemporary discussion.

[2] See the discussion of inductive support in the second section below, where the generalisation is stated more carefully.

[3] This objection is sometimes called the problem of the global justification of testimony; I set aside here the question of whether local justification fares better. It is worth stressing that the objection does not depend on any particular account of induction, and that it applies equally to probabilistic and non-probabilistic versions of the view. A full treatment would also need to consider the role of memory, since much of what we know from testimony we no longer remember having been told, and the reductionist must say how the original inductive support is preserved across that gap. I return to a version of this worry in the final section.

2. Evidence and Entitlement

What remains contested is the direction of explanation. The reductionist explains the default by appeal to evidence; the anti-reductionist explains the role of evidence by appeal to the default, treating counter-evidence as something that defeats an entitlement already in place rather than as something that must be accumulated before belief is permitted.

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> To believe on the word of another is not to suspend judgement but to exercise it in a particular way, by placing one’s reliance where one has reason to think it will be honoured.

[4] Compare the parallel entitlement often claimed for perception and memory.

[5] I owe this way of putting the point to conversations with colleagues.